

Where Scandal Became Procedure

James Wilkinson, Thomas Jefferson, and Frederick-Town in the Politics of Survival

Repository Example for a Humanities Workflow

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Abstract

James Wilkinson’s long survival in national office has usually been told as a story of intrigue, nerve, or presidential indulgence. The Frederick record points to something more concrete. It shows how executive confidence was translated into venue, counsel, witnesses, interrogatories, and finally acquittal. Read together, the Jefferson–Wilkinson correspondence, a 1800 War Department receipt from Frederick Town, the 1808 presidential message on Wilkinson’s inquiry, the 1811 Frederick court-martial letters, and Madison’s approval of the acquittal reveal Frederick not as incidental scenery but as one of the places where scandal was given legal and administrative form. Jefferson’s importance remains central, but not because he simply trusted Wilkinson as a friend. His support mattered because it kept Wilkinson within reach of formal vindication long enough for the case to be processed. Frederick mattered because that processing happened there. The town was one of the working sites at which political protection became procedure and procedure became survival.

1 Introduction

James Wilkinson is one of the most difficult early American figures to write about because the verdict on his character arrives long before the analysis begins. He is remembered as ambitious, compromised, evasive, and, in many accounts, indefensibly corrupt. Yet he also remained near the center of federal power for decades. That endurance poses a better historical question than the simple moral one. How did he survive?

For a Frederick audience, the question becomes sharper. Wilkinson’s story usually belongs to western intrigues, the Burr conspiracy, or the early republic’s military weakness. Frederick, Maryland, appears only in passing, if at all. But the Frederick record suggests that the town was not merely scenery. It was one of the places where Wilkinson’s political damage was managed, judged, and partly repaired.

This paper asks how Wilkinson’s usefulness to Jefferson was made politically durable. The surviving letters do not support a naive friendship story. They show something more revealing: Wilkinson made himself useful through western intelligence, scientific curiosities, and crisis management; Jefferson in turn protected him at crucial moments because abandoning him would also have weakened the administration’s western policy and Burr narrative [Jefferson, 1807, Wilkinson, 1807a, Onuf, 2000, Lewis, 2017]. Yet executive protection did not mean blind indulgence. In January 1808 Jefferson told the House that Wilkinson’s case had already been placed before a court of inquiry and promised that the matter would be pursued with “rigorous impartiality” [Jefferson, 1808]. The real historical problem, then, is not simply what Jefferson thought of Wilkinson, but

how confidence at the top of government was converted into institutional judgment. By 1811 and 1812 that conversion was taking place through venue choice, witness management, interrogatories, counsel, and final approval. In this case, the documentary trail leads to Frederick-town [Wilkinson, 1811b, Madison, 1812]. That question belongs not only to political biography but to the history of executive management and military administration in the early republic [Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983, Watson, 2012].

Modern scholarship has usually met Wilkinson in one of three ways. Biographers have emphasized duplicity, opportunism, and his extraordinary ability to escape the consequences of his conduct [Jacobs, 1938, Linklater, 2009, Cox, 2023]. Studies of the Burr crisis have treated him as a central actor in a larger national emergency shaped by rumor, fear, and the unstable politics of loyalty [Lewis, 2017, Sharp, 1993, Wood, 2009]. Work on honor and scandal in the early republic has made clear that such crises were fought not only through facts but through confidence, slander, vindication, and official backing [Freeman, 2002, Kierner, 2024]. Scholarship on military authority and the officer corps further suggests that questions of loyalty, usefulness, and protection were inseparable from the administrative life of the early national state [Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983, Watson, 2012]. This paper joins that literature at a more local scale. It asks where Wilkinson's survival became administratively and legally durable.

The local angle deepens rather than narrows the problem. Frederick appears in at least four distinct ways. First, a War Department receipt from 2 December 1800 places Wilkinson and his suite in Frederick Town itself, showing that the town was already part of his military-administrative geography before the famous crisis years [Papers of the War Department, 1800]. Second, Wilkinson had an older Maryland footing near Monocacy, recorded in later archival description and echoed in local county history [University of Michigan William L. Clements Library, 2025, Tracey and Dern, 1987]. Third, the town belonged to the military geography of the Jeffersonian West, with the Frederick Barracks serving as a depot for Lewis and Clark in 1802 [Historic Frederick Barracks Historical Marker, 2024, Onuf, 2000]. Fourth, and most important, Frederick-town became the administrative and legal setting in which Wilkinson's crisis was organized, heard, and ratified. By late summer 1811 the War Department understood Frederick as the intended venue; by September Madison was leaving the case in the hands of the Frederick tribunal while Eustis arranged attendance for the requested officers; by October interrogatories and appeals were moving in and out of Frederick Town as part of the defense record [Eustis, 1811a, Madison, 1811, Eustis, 1811b, Kinson, 1811, Wilkinson, 1811b, Adams, 1811]. In the broader literature on military justice and administration, those are not incidental details. They are the mechanics by which accusation became a formal proceeding and formal proceeding became settlement [Lurie, 2001, Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983]. Put differently, Frederick stood at the junction of western empire, military infrastructure, and procedural survival.

That framing places the paper in a narrower lane than a full Wilkinson biography. The question here is not whether he deserves rescue from his reputation. It is how a compromised man remained usable, and where that usefulness was turned into a survivable official result. For a Frederick audience, the town's importance lies not in having touched a notorious figure, but in having helped shape the form through which his crisis was judged.

The argument proceeds in four steps. Section 2 makes the evidence ladder explicit so that direct presidential correspondence, Frederick procedure documents, and later local amplifications are not pressed with the same force. Section 3 reconstructs the Jefferson–Wilkinson relationship across three phases: access through usefulness, crisis through protection, and afterlife through

remembered service. Section 4 shows how Frederick turned that political protection into venue, evidence, and judgment. Section 5 uses a small coded corpus to check whether the prose claims match the documentary pattern. The result is a local-history argument built on a compact but inspectable documentary base.

The paper makes two main claims. The first is interpretive: Wilkinson’s tie to Jefferson was politically personal and survival-oriented rather than simply affectionate. The second is local and structural: Frederick Town was one of the key places in which executive protection became procedure, evidence, and official settlement.

2 Sources and Approach

The evidence base for this paper is deliberately compact and transparent. The curated corpus now contains twenty-four records:

- twenty-one primary or near-primary documents from *Founders Online*, the *Papers of the War Department*, and Jefferson’s 1808 presidential message on the Wilkinson inquiry;
- three local or public-history sources tied specifically to Frederick and Wilkinson’s Maryland geography.

The package now releases this corpus in a more explicit audit form as well: a compact inventory with stable URLs and repository identifiers, plus a traceability file preserving the exact excerpts and summaries used for coding.

The primary records focus on three clusters. The first cluster covers early access and usefulness: the 1800 Frederick Town receipt for Wilkinson’s suite, Jefferson’s 1801 effort to reach both Wilkinson and Meriwether Lewis through the same forwarding network, Wilkinson’s 1802 gift of river-water samples and fossils, the 1804 dinner invitation, and the 1805 buffalo-hide map letter [Papers of the War Department, 1800, Jefferson, 1801, Wilkinson, 1802, 1804b, 1805]. The second cluster centers on the Burr crisis, where Jefferson’s support and Wilkinson’s anxious replies reveal a relationship of mutual need rather than sentiment. It now also includes Jefferson’s January 1808 special message, which shows him moving the Wilkinson matter into a court of inquiry while still managing it as an executive problem [Jefferson, 1807, Wilkinson, 1807a,b, Jefferson, 1808]. The third cluster covers rehabilitation and afterlife. It includes Wilkinson’s 1811 memoir campaign and Jefferson’s reassuring response, but it now also includes a fuller Frederick procedural chain: venue planning inside the War Department, Madison’s refusal to preempt the Frederick tribunal, witness orders, interrogatories sent from Frederick Town, Wilkinson’s own complaint to Madison, Adams’s testimonial reply, Madison’s approval of the acquittal, and the 1818 exchange of retrospective esteem [Wilkinson, 1811a, Jefferson, 1811, Eustis, 1811a, Madison, 1811, Eustis, 1811b, Kinson, 1811, Wilkinson, 1811b, Adams, 1811, Madison, 1812, Jefferson, 1818, Wilkinson, 1818].

The local sources were chosen for function, not decoration. The Frederick Barracks marker preserves the claim that the barracks served both Lewis and Clark and later War of 1812 military traffic [Historic Frederick Barracks Historical Marker, 2024]. The Clements Library finding aid preserves the biographical note that Wilkinson practiced medicine in Monocacy, Maryland [University of Michigan William L. Clements Library, 2025]. The Maryland Historical Magazine article on Roger Brooke Taney preserves the later tradition that Frederick lawyers defended Wilkinson without fee during the court-martial [Delaplaine, 1918]. Read against the older Taney biographies, the Thomas

Evidence tier	Records
Direct Jefferson–Wilkinson primary correspondence	11
Primary Frederick venue and outcome records	9
Contextual Frederick local sources	3
Primary share of Frederick-linked corpus	75%

Table 1: Evidence ladder for the paper’s core claims. The Jefferson–Wilkinson thesis rests mostly on direct correspondence, while the Frederick synthesis combines a substantial primary procedural chain with contextual local sources.

Johnson and John Hanson Thomas biographical materials at the Maryland State Archives, and the *Frederick-Town Herald* directory entry at the Library of Congress, that tradition belongs to a real Frederick legal and print world even if it does not settle every factual detail on its own [Swisher, 1935, Smith, 1936, Huebner, 2010, Maryland State Archives, 2026a,b, Library of Congress, 2026a]. None of these sources is sufficient alone; together they thicken the local setting around a primary Frederick dossier that is now much stronger than it was at the start of this project.

The claim structure is therefore tiered. The paper’s strongest argument — that Jefferson and Wilkinson were linked more by utility, protection, and political management than by simple intimacy — rests mainly on the eleven direct Jefferson–Wilkinson records and the surrounding official correspondence. The Frederick argument is now strongest where Frederick appears in primary or near-primary documents as a venue of reputational defense, court-martial procedure, evidence gathering, and presidentially acknowledged acquittal. It is more interpretive where the local role depends on later public-history or biographical framing. Making that distinction explicit matters for a local-history audience: Frederick is important here, but not every part of its importance stands on the same evidentiary footing.

The interpretive frame, however, is broader than the corpus. This reading of Wilkinson is informed by older and newer biography, by scholarship on the Burr crisis, by studies of honor, rumor, and political reputation in the early republic, and by work on military justice and administration [Jacobs, 1938, Linklater, 2009, Cox, 2023, Lewis, 2017, Freeman, 2002, Kierner, 2024, Lurie, 2001, Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983, Watson, 2012]. Those works do not supply the paper’s local evidence. They do help explain why the language of utility, defense, esteem, venue, and procedural settlement belongs to the period rather than to retrospective editorial invention.

Table 1 makes that hierarchy visible. The Frederick claim is not built from one sort of record alone. It now stands on a nine-document primary chain — from the 1800 Frederick Town receipt and the 1804 Frederick Town letter to Adams through the 1811 War Department and interrogatory record to Madison’s 1812 approval of the Frederick-town acquittal — then thickens that chain with three local contextual sources. That layered structure is exactly why the paper can make a confident local argument without pretending every sentence has the same documentary force.

Table 2 makes the Frederick dossier inspectable in a second way: not just by count, but by function. The primary records do different argumentative jobs. Taken together, they show venue choice, executive restraint, witness management, outward evidence collection, plea, testimonial return, and formal federal settlement.

The coded layer is modest by design. It assigns each record a phase, relationship mode, and Frederick role; generates an event timeline; counts a small lexicon of warmth, utility, and defense terms in the excerpted correspondence; and builds a weighted network from the named relationships

Year	Document	Function in argument
1804	Wilkinson to Adams on fame	Shows Frederick as an early site of reputational self-defense
1811	Eustis on venue	Shows Frederick chosen in advance as the intended court-martial venue
1811	Madison on jurisdiction	Shows the president leaving the Frederick tribunal in possession of the case
1811	Eustis on witness orders	Shows the War Department mobilizing officers for the Frederick proceedings
1811	Wilkinson on fairness	Shows Frederick as the place where Wilkinson sought procedural fairness
1811	Kinson with interrogatories	Shows Frederick reaching outward to collect testimony by interrogatory
1812	Madison on acquittal	Puts Frederick into the federal record through approved acquittal
1811	Adams in reply	Shows national testimony flowing back into the Frederick defense record

Table 2: The Frederick primary documentary chain used in the paper’s core local argument. These records show venue choice, jurisdiction, evidence gathering, plea, and settlement before later contextual sources are added.

Metric	Value
Coded records in corpus	24
Frederick-linked records	12 (50%)
Frederick-linked records in rehabilitation phase	7
Non-social survival modes	18
Pure social-access mode	1
Retrospective-esteem mode	2

Table 3: Core metrics from the coded corpus. The counts support a relationship defined much more by use and protection than by simple friendship.

in the corpus. These outputs are heuristic. They do not decide the argument on their own, and network position should not be confused with causal proof. Their value is disciplinary rather than magical. If the prose claims that the relationship was mostly instrumental, or that Frederick was more than incidental, the documentary pattern has to carry that weight. The released inventory, traceability, sensitivity, and environment files are intended to make that weight easier to inspect.

The method also makes the paper easier to challenge in concrete ways. A corpus dominated by private-social records would weaken the claim that usefulness mattered more than friendship. A Frederick set made up only of late local memory would weaken the argument that Frederick was procedurally important rather than ceremonially convenient. The evidence is laid out this way so that readers can test those possibilities directly instead of taking the interpretation on trust.

The first descriptive result is already revealing. Of the twenty-four coded records, twelve are Frederick-linked. Only one record is primarily a social-access document, the 1804 dinner invitation note. By contrast, eighteen turn on use, defense, procedure, testimony, or settlement. The Frederick-linked subset is also not a one-note cluster: it spans logistical presence, reputational repair, venue choice, jurisdiction, witness coordination, interrogatory collection, trial venue, trial

outcome, external testimony, infrastructure, local origin, and legal alliance. The numbers do not replace reading, but they do caution against an overly sentimental portrait.

3 Jefferson and Wilkinson: Access, Usefulness, Protection

The surviving record suggests that Jefferson and Wilkinson were neither strangers nor intimate friends. They occupied a more typical but harder-to-name early republican relationship: proximity built from usefulness, then tested by crisis.

The relationship is easiest to understand in three stages. The first stage, from 1801 to 1805, is access through usefulness: Wilkinson keeps bringing Jefferson things he can use, whether information, specimens, maps, or western intermediaries. The second stage, centered on 1807, is survival through executive protection: Jefferson's backing matters because Burr makes Wilkinson simultaneously valuable and vulnerable. The third stage, from 1811 to 1818, is memory through selective esteem: Jefferson does not canonize Wilkinson's character, but he continues to credit his services and refuses to join the loudest chorus of suspicion. Read this way, the relationship has a shape. It is political intimacy under pressure, not ordinary friendship.

The early correspondence shows Wilkinson presenting himself as a man worth keeping in Jefferson's circle because he could provide western knowledge, objects, and personnel. In 1802 he sent river-water samples and fossils because they "may not be unacceptable" to Jefferson [Wilkinson, 1802]. In 1805 he forwarded a buffalo-hide map and vouched for Captain Amos Stoddard as a man of intelligence, closing with "perfect respect" and "sincere attachment" [Wilkinson, 1805]. Even the 1804 dinner note is revealing: social access existed, but it was immediately absorbed back into public business through Humboldt, Texas, and Mexico [Wilkinson, 1804b]. The relationship was personal enough for dinner, but the dinner itself seems to have been another venue for utility.

That distinction matters for the paper's use of the phrase *personal relationship*. The letters do show manners, favors, invitations, and affective language. But in early republican elite correspondence those signals do not automatically mean private friendship in the modern sense. They often indicate access, patronage, and mutual placement within a governing circle. Wilkinson's surviving language toward Jefferson is therefore best read as politically personal rather than domestically intimate: close enough for favors, never detached from usefulness.

That pattern became explicit during the Burr crisis. Jefferson's letter of 3 February 1807 is the clearest proof that Wilkinson's survival was tied to presidential need. Jefferson reassured him that "we ... have not failed to strengthen the public confidence in you" and promised that he would be "cordially supported in the line of your duties" [Jefferson, 1807]. That is not the language of detached neutrality. It is the language of a president who needs his general's credibility to hold while Burr's conspiracy is being narrated to the nation.

Wilkinson understood the asymmetry perfectly. His answer of 20 March 1807 thanked Jefferson for the "sweet Solace" of sympathy and described presidential support as "the warrant of part confidence & the pledge of future trust" [Wilkinson, 1807a]. In April he went further and looked "for Orders & direction" concerning "time & place" [Wilkinson, 1807b]. Wilkinson was not writing as a friend seeking consolation. He was writing as a compromised subordinate who needed executive endorsement to remain a usable instrument.

The 1811 exchange sharpens the point. Wilkinson's memoir letter to Jefferson is drenched in persecution and honor. He writes under "the pressure of my persecutions" and presents his memoirs as a weapon against public falsehood [Wilkinson, 1811a]. Jefferson's answer is warm but carefully

Author	Warmth	Utility	Defense	Total
James Wilkinson	4	5	6	15
Thomas Jefferson	2	5	3	10

Table 4: Lexicon counts from excerpted correspondence and summaries. Wilkinson’s surviving voice is especially saturated with defense language, while Jefferson’s is warmer only when folded into judgment and utility.

Phase	Inst.	Prot.	Self-vind.	Proced.	Official	Esteem	Testimony
Access / utility	3	0	0	0	0	0	0
Frontier brokerage	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
Burr crisis	0	4	0	0	0	0	0
Frederick repair	0	0	1	0	0	0	0
Rehabilitation	0	1	1	3	1	0	1
Retrospective memory	0	0	0	0	0	2	0
Local context	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

Table 5: Phase-by-mode summary from the coded corpus. The Burr crisis is almost purely protective, while rehabilitation mixes self-defense, procedure, testimony, and official settlement.

framed. He dismisses the “under my thumb” slander, says he believes Wilkinson because of his own knowledge of Burr and Wilkinson’s conduct, and hopes the general’s “Argosy may ride out” the storm [Jefferson, 1811]. The letter matters because Jefferson refuses to join the chorus of suspicion. Yet even here the belief is grounded in political history and conduct, not in intimate testimony about character.

Madison’s role shows the next step in the same survival chain. Jefferson supplied reassurance, memory, and interpretive cover. Madison later supplied ratification. The distinction matters because Wilkinson did not survive only by remaining believable to Jefferson; he survived when executive sympathy was translated into a restored commission and an approved acquittal. Put differently, Jefferson helped keep Wilkinson politically viable, but Madison helped certify that viability in federal form.

The tables make the stage structure easier to see. Wilkinson’s excerpted voice in this corpus carries more defense terms than warmth terms, while Jefferson’s language balances warmth with utility and judgment. The phase-by-mode summary then shows why: the Burr crisis collapses almost entirely into protection, while the rehabilitation cluster mixes self-vindication, War Department procedure, testimonial gathering, and official settlement. Wilkinson needed Jefferson more urgently than Jefferson needed Wilkinson personally; Jefferson needed Wilkinson primarily when western policy, Burr, or later retrospective memory made him useful. The 1818 correspondence confirms the shift. Jefferson’s estimate of Wilkinson’s services remained “unaltered,” and Wilkinson treasured the “approbation & esteem” as recognition long denied by the public [Jefferson, 1818, Wilkinson, 1818]. What remained, then, was not intimacy in the ordinary sense. It was a durable politics of remembered service.

4 Where Scandal Became Procedure

Once the relationship is seen as one of utility and protection rather than friendship, Frederick's importance becomes clearer. Wilkinson did not survive in the abstract. He survived through venues, procedures, witnesses, local counsel, and official ratification. Frederick is one of the places where that process can be followed document by document. It is not simply the town in which the court-martial happened to sit. It is one of the places where scandal was converted into an administrative and legal sequence that the federal government could recognize.

The sequence now begins earlier and runs more continuously than the paper first suggested. A War Department receipt from 2 December 1800 records payment for "forage and subsistence" for Wilkinson and his suite in Frederick Town [Papers of the War Department, 1800]. It is a small document, but a useful one, because it shows Frederick in Wilkinson's federal military geography well before the later crisis years. By September 1804 he was already writing from Frederick Town to John Adams in order to justify his conduct and preserve "my Fame" against attack [Wilkinson, 1804a]. That letter matters because it shows Frederick before the famous court-martial, already serving as a place from which Wilkinson answered challenges to his authority.

The 1811 record then turns Frederick from setting into mechanism. In August, William Eustis reported to Madison that Wilkinson intended to have the court-martial "in Frederick town" [Eustis, 1811a]. By mid-September Madison was treating the case as already "in possession of the Court Martial" at Frederick Town and saw no reason to interrupt it with further executive instructions [Madison, 1811]. Ten days later Eustis reported that orders had gone out to secure the attendance of the officers requested by the court [Eustis, 1811b]. These letters do not merely place the trial in Frederick. They show the venue being chosen, respected, and supplied. In the terms used by historians of military justice, they also show that the proceeding was administrative as well as local: jurisdiction, witness procurement, and executive restraint were all part of the machinery by which accusation acquired legal force [Lurie, 2001, Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983].

The October papers deepen the point. From Frederick Town, Jabeil Kinson sent interrogatories to Adams "by order of the General Court Martial" [Kinson, 1811]. Wilkinson himself then wrote from Frederick Town to Madison that the proceedings should remain "free & unbiased" and without even the appearance that he was being denied "a fair & impartial decision" [Wilkinson, 1811b]. Adams replied that he considered the old rumors against Wilkinson "Calumnies" and answered the interrogatories accordingly [Adams, 1811]. By then Frederick was no longer just the place where the court sat. It was the operating address from which evidence was gathered, fairness was pleaded, and distant testimony was drawn back into the defense. The town had become an active instrument in the making of a judgment.

That procedural record clarifies the paper's executive logic. Jefferson's letters mattered because they sustained Wilkinson's credibility in the face of scandal. Jefferson's 1808 special message matters because it shows that such support did not preclude formal scrutiny; the executive had already placed the affair before a court of inquiry and tied it to the Clark evidence and the wider Burr crisis [Jefferson, 1808]. Madison's role then mattered because he oversaw the governmental transition from inquiry and sympathy to enforceable settlement. When Madison later informed Jefferson that he had examined the proceedings of the "General Court Martial held at Frederick-town" and approved Wilkinson's acquittal, ordering Wilkinson's sword restored, Frederick was written into the federal record of survival itself [Madison, 1812]. The editorial note accompanying that letter preserves part of the court's own conclusion: Wilkinson, it reported, had discharged his duties "with

zeal and fidelity” and “merits the approbation of his country” [Madison, 1812]. Even before the full pamphlet and case file are in hand, that surviving wording shows the sort of judgment Frederick produced. That sequence looks less accidental when set beside the broader literature on early republican civil-military management, where command, confidence, and institutional continuity were often bound together [Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983, Watson, 2012].

The local contextual sources now read in a more disciplined order. A later archival note that Wilkinson practiced medicine near Monocacy keeps Frederick County in his older Maryland world [University of Michigan William L. Clements Library, 2025, Tracey and Dern, 1987]. The Frederick Barracks marker places the town inside the military geography of the Jeffersonian West, though it should not be asked to prove more than that [Historic Frederick Barracks Historical Marker, 2024, Onuf, 2000]. The later Taney tradition should likewise be used carefully. Its value lies less in settling every detail of the defense than in preserving how Frederick remembered the case: not as a passing spectacle, but as a serious legal undertaking [Delaplaine, 1918]. That memory is no longer resting on one late local article alone. The Maryland State Archives biography of John Hanson Thomas repeats the same basic story, naming both Thomas and Taney as Wilkinson’s counsel and tying the defense to Frederick’s later partisan and newspaper culture [Maryland State Archives, 2026a]. The corresponding source page identifies two *Frederick-Town Herald* notices for Thomas, dated 6 and 27 May 1815, and the biography preserves the newspaper’s tribute that his death “has left a chasm in society which can not be filled” [Maryland State Archives, 2026c,a]. That does not prove every detail of the Wilkinson defense, but it does show that one of Wilkinson’s counsel stood high enough in Frederick life for the town’s newspaper to mark his loss in those terms. Read alongside Taney scholarship, that tradition sits within a recognizable Frederick legal milieu rather than floating free of context [Swisher, 1935, Smith, 1936, Huebner, 2010]. These sources thicken the setting. They no longer have to carry the core claim on their own.

The corpus-level place ranking reinforces the same conclusion from another angle. Frederick Town is not merely one Maryland location among several. It is the heaviest place node in the source network and remains among the largest nodes even when the later local-context materials are removed. That prominence does not prove causality by itself, but it supports the narrower claim the paper now makes with more confidence: Frederick was one of the main local geographies in which Wilkinson’s survival was made workable.

That is why the Frederick angle is not a local flourish. It changes the argument. Wilkinson survived because presidential protection met a place where scandal could be processed into venue, testimony, judgment, and official settlement. Frederick mattered not as a backdrop to survival but as one of its working forms.

5 Patterns in the Corpus

The tables and figures in this section are deliberately simple. Their purpose is not to turn a small humanities corpus into a false science. It is to make the paper’s descriptive claims easier to inspect.

First, the event timeline shows that Frederick-linked records are not evenly distributed. They cluster in two meaningful zones. One is the earlier zone of Maryland footing and reputational management, including the Monocacy context and the 1804 Adams letter. The other is the rehabilitation zone of 1811 and 1812, where Frederick becomes the court-martial site and the place from which Wilkinson appeals directly to presidential fairness. The point is not merely that Frederick appears often. It appears when Wilkinson is most in need of repair.

Author	Warmth / 1000 tok.	Utility / 1000 tok.	Defense / 1000 tok.
James Wilkinson	10.93	13.66	16.39
Thomas Jefferson	8.16	20.41	12.24

Table 6: Normalized theme rates per 1000 tokens in the coded excerpts and summaries. The normalized view still leaves Wilkinson’s voice more defense-heavy than warmth-heavy, while Jefferson remains most associated with utility language.

Primary-only node	Weight
James Wilkinson	32
Thomas Jefferson	18
Frederick Town	18
James Madison	9
Aaron Burr	7

Table 7: Top nodes in the primary-only connection network. Frederick Town remains one of the heaviest nodes even when the later local-context sources are removed.

without reopening every scandal.

The normalized theme-rate check in Table 6 makes the same point more conservatively. Once token volume is taken into account, Wilkinson still runs defense-heavier than warmth, while Jefferson remains most closely associated with utility language. That does not turn a small lexicon into sentiment science. It simply shows that the asymmetry survives a stricter denominator.

Fifth, the evidence-tier counts help show why the local argument is stronger than a ceremonial hometown claim. Nearly three quarters of the Frederick-linked corpus is primary. The Frederick set now includes not just an early reputational-defense letter, a plea for fairness, and an acquittal notice, but also venue planning, jurisdiction management, witness coordination, interrogatory practice, and testimonial return. That balance matters because it means the paper is not deriving its Frederick thesis from later local boosterism alone.

The primary-only network provides a related robustness check. Once the later local-context materials are removed, Frederick Town remains tied with Jefferson as the second-heaviest node in the connection graph, behind only Wilkinson. That is the right result for this paper. It does not mean Frederick outweighs the national actors. It means Frederick remains structurally visible even in the documentary core.

The place-node ranking sharpens the local point further. Frederick Town outranks the Frederick Barracks and Monocacy both in the full corpus and in the primary-only subset. That matters because it shows the argument is not simply about any Maryland geography touching Wilkinson. It is specifically about Frederick as the most active local place in the documentary chain of survival.

The current revision adds one more modest robustness layer. An excerpt-only lexicon pass and a more conservative dictionary preserve the same directional asymmetry between Wilkinson’s defensive language and Jefferson’s utility language, while leave-one-out perturbations still leave Frederick Town as the leading place node. These checks do not substitute for second-coder validation, but they make it less likely that the main descriptive pattern is a one-pass artifact of this exact phrasing choice.

These results are best understood as corroboration. They do not replace historical judgment, and the corpus is too selective to support extravagant quantitative claims. They do, however, make

Place node	Full corpus	Primary-only
Frederick Town	22	18
Frederick Barracks	3	0
Monocacy	2	0

Table 8: Place-node ranking in the connection network. Frederick Town dominates both in the full corpus and in the primary-only subset, reinforcing its role as the paper’s central local geography.

one thing harder to deny: if a local society wants to know why Frederick matters in the Wilkinson story, the answer is visible not only in prose but in the shape, timing, and evidentiary layering of the surviving record itself.

6 Conclusion

James Wilkinson survived because he was useful before he was defensible. Jefferson’s relationship with him was built on that usefulness, especially in the western theater and during the Burr crisis. When accusations mounted, Jefferson’s support and later Madison’s approval did not erase suspicion. They did something narrower and more political: they kept him within reach of formal vindication. In that respect Wilkinson belongs to a larger early republic story in which reputation, command, and executive management were closely entangled [Freeman, 2002, Kohn, 1975, Stagg, 1983].

Frederick matters because viability needed a place. Wilkinson’s older Maryland footing and the barracks’ connection to Jeffersonian western logistics still matter as background, but the heart of the case now lies elsewhere: the 1800 War Department receipt, the 1804 Frederick letter to Adams, Jefferson’s 1808 public insistence on inquiry, the 1811 venue and witness letters between Eustis and Madison, the interrogatories sent from Frederick Town, Wilkinson’s own plea for an unbiased hearing, Adams’s testimonial reply, and the 1812 approval of the Frederick-town acquittal. Read together, those records show Frederick as one of the towns in which national scandal became manageable federal procedure [Lurie, 2001].

That is the paper’s main contribution. It reframes a notorious national figure through the local machinery that made his survival possible. For a Frederick historical society, the most important takeaway is not that Wilkinson once appeared there. It is that Frederick helped turn a national scandal into a sequence of proceedings that could end in acquittal and restored standing. Frederick was not an incidental stage set. It was one of the working mechanisms.

The note should still be read with evidentiary discipline. The core relationship claim rests most securely on direct correspondence and official records. The Frederick claim is now stronger than a simple local gloss because most of its documentary chain is primary, but the thicker local texture still depends in part on a small number of later Frederick-centered sources. That does not weaken the synthesis, but it does define its proper scale: this paper offers a strong, source-accountable interpretation, not the last archival word on Wilkinson.

That scale is also what makes the paper useful for public history. A local historical society does not need Wilkinson to become admirable in order for Frederick to matter. It needs a documented account of how local place entered a national political story. On that narrower but important question, the evidence is strong. Frederick appears not as a sentimental hometown cameo but as one of the places through which executive protection was turned into durable official form.

There is also a public-history reason to keep difficult actors in view. Wilkinson is not valuable because he is morally exemplary. He is valuable because compromised figures often show most clearly how institutions, places, and reputations actually work. Following him does not ask Frederick to celebrate him. It asks the town to recognize that local history can illuminate national power most sharply when it traces how messy lives were processed, defended, and judged.

If this note were expanded for a broader scholarly venue, the next archival step would be clear: a deeper integration of the printed court-martial report, the NARA Record Group 153 case file, the Jefferson Papers guides and correspondence lists, Frederick newspaper abstracts and surviving issues, Frederick legal manuscripts, and the Taney papers to test how far the Frederick-centered procedural story can be extended beyond the compact documentary chain used here [The Morgan Library & Museum, 1812, National Archives and Records Administration, 2026, Library of Congress, 2026b,d,c, Wright, 1992, University of Virginia Law Library, 2026].

A Appendix: Corpus Design

The corpus in this package is intentionally small and auditable. Each record stores:

- date and location;
- author and recipient;
- phase of Wilkinson’s career;
- a relationship-mode label;
- optional Frederick-role coding;
- a short excerpt and summary;
- source URL;
- named connections used for the network figure.

This design makes the paper easy to inspect and criticize. A reader can disagree with the coding while still seeing exactly how the paper’s figures were produced. That transparency matters for a humanities workflow because it prevents the computational layer from turning into black-box authority.

Audit Trail and Environment

The package now releases the corpus in three progressively denser forms:

- `data/source_manifest.json` describes the package at the source level;
- `data/corpus_inventory.json` gives the full twenty-four-record inventory with stable URLs and repository identifiers;
- `data/evidence_traceability.json` preserves the exact excerpts and summaries used in coding;

- `code/environment_versions.json` records the runtime environment for the current build.

Together these files make the paper easier to audit than a narrative note whose data trail is left implicit.

Coding Rules

Three coding rules matter especially for this note. First, a record is marked Frederick-linked only if Frederick, Frederick Town, Monocacy, the Frederick Barracks, or a clearly Frederick-based legal alliance is part of the document’s historical function rather than a passing geographic mention. Second, direct Jefferson–Wilkinson correspondence is kept analytically distinct from surrounding official or local material because it carries the strongest weight for the relationship claim. Third, later local sources are used to thicken setting and legal memory, not to outrank contemporaneous presidential or court-martial records.

Inclusion Logic

The corpus is not a complete Wilkinson archive. It is a purpose-built working set designed to answer one question well: how Jeffersonian protection and Frederick procedure intersected in Wilkinson’s survival. A record is included if it illuminates at least one of four functions: access and usefulness, executive protection, Frederick as venue or infrastructure, Frederick procedure or testimony, or retrospective memory. That inclusion logic keeps the package compact enough for a local-history audience to audit while still broad enough to test the paper’s main interpretive claim.

What Is Not Included

This corpus does not attempt to exhaust every possible Wilkinson source class. It does not include the full court-martial transcript, the complete Burr-era newspaper war, or the wider Wilkinson manuscript universe in Maryland, Louisiana, and federal military records. Those omissions matter if the goal is a larger archival monograph. They matter less for the narrower claim of this paper, which asks how Jeffersonian protection and Frederick procedure appear in a compact, inspectable documentary chain. The exclusions therefore limit the scale of the claim without collapsing it.

Proceedings Note

The coded corpus still does not include the full printed court-martial proceedings or the complete RG 153 case file. The paper therefore relies on the procedural letters as its primary chain. To narrow that gap, the present revision also uses the editorial note accompanying Madison’s 7 February 1812 letter, which preserves a favorable fragment of the court’s own language [Madison, 1812]. It also notes Wilkinson’s complaint a few weeks later that at least one transcribed copy of the proceedings had been made in haste and with errors, a reminder that the surviving record has to be handled critically even when it is official [Wilkinson, 1812]. The next archival gains are therefore clear: the printed pamphlet, the RG 153 file, and any surviving Frederick press or docket material that can confirm how the proceeding looked on the ground.

Spelling in the corpus follows the cited source transcription. The form “Jabeil Kinson,” for example, is kept because that is how the Founders Online text for the Adams interrogatory letter presents the name.

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